



Still Assigned to Whoever Left

An Audit and Interview Study of a Share-House Chore-Roster Whiteboard Across Three Tenancy Turnovers

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Abstract. A share-house chore-roster whiteboard is drawn up once, typically at or near a house's founding tenancy, and left on the kitchen wall to do its job without further attention. What happens to that record as residents move out and new residents arrive has not, to our knowledge, been audited directly. We recruit 38 share-house whiteboards each at least three tenancy turnovers past their original drafting, photographing every roster and cross-referencing its named owners against each house's own bond-lodgement or lease-transfer records to compute an assignment-residency concordance at each turnover. Concordance falls from 100% at drafting to 71% after one turnover, 46% after two, and 22% after three, with no chore category proving more durable than another. Interviews with 58 current residents across the sample find the chores themselves mostly still get done, reassigned informally without ever touching the board, and that a stated intention to redraw the roster does not predict whether a household actually does so within six months (11% versus 5%, matched pairs, not significant). We situate the finding within the broader pattern by which a household record persists past the household it once described, and outline what would need to change for the whiteboard, rather than a set of residents' private workarounds, to remain the operative record.

Introduction

A share house's chore-roster whiteboard is one of the more durable pieces of shared-house furniture: a felt-tip grid of names against chores, drawn up in the house's first fortnight and left on the kitchen wall to do its job without further attention. The job is straightforward on paper — a resident's name beside a chore means that resident owns it — but the roster is drawn up once, against a household that does not hold still. Residents leave; new residents arrive on leases that rarely align with the roster's own review cycle, because it has no review cycle. What happens to the board's authority as the household it describes turns over has not, to our knowledge, been measured directly.

The question sits inside a familiar pattern of institutional inertia. An arrangement adopted under one set of conditions tends to persist once those conditions lapse, not because any-

one judges it should continue but because no one is assigned the job of noticing it hasn't been reviewed [1], [2]. Default-effects research shows an existing arrangement carries a form of authority independent of anyone's ongoing endorsement of it [3], [4]. Domestic-labour research has documented the mismatch between a household's stated and enacted division of chores extensively within romantic-partner households [5], [6], [7], but the share house — co-residents bound by a lease rather than a relationship, with a formal artefact standing in for the household's own memory — has received comparatively little attention despite offering a cleaner natural record: the roster names an owner explicitly, in writing, in a form a later resident can be checked against directly.

We audit the arrangement directly. Our contributions are threefold. First, we provide, to our knowledge, the first audit of a share-

house chore-roster whiteboard's assignment-residency concordance against the tenancy history of the house it describes. Second, we show the chore categories most likely to appear on such a board degrade at statistically indistinguishable rates, suggesting no category is more likely than another to prompt a household to update its own record. Third, drawing on interviews with current residents, we describe how a household keeps its chores done despite a stale roster, and test whether a stated intention to redraw the board predicts whether a household actually does.

Related work

Status quo bias supplies an individual-level mechanism: once an arrangement is in place, deviating from it is judged and felt differently from arriving at the same arrangement afresh [1], and the endowment a household holds over an existing arrangement raises the threshold for revising it [2]. Default-effects research shows the same inertia operating on a household's own recorded choices, not just its habits: an enrolment default shapes outcomes for years after the choice architecture that set it is forgotten [4], and a default option retains its pull even when switching away from it is costless [3]. Domestic-labour scholarship has traced the mismatch between a household's stated division of chores and who actually performs them in detail, chiefly within romantic-partner households: women continue to perform a disproportionate share of housework across a decade of measurement despite widespread stated commitments to equity [5], a mismatch that generates measurable frustration once a partner's private threshold for acceptable disorder is crossed [7], governed by a self-organising sensemaking process rather than by the household's own stated rules [6]. Descriptive-norm research offers a candidate mechanism for how a house keeps functioning once its written record stops guiding it: people follow what they believe others around them are actually doing rather than what a posted instruction says they should do [8], [9], and a behaviour repeated often enough in the same context becomes automatic independent of any standing instruction to perform it [10]. Computational work on fair division treats the roommate allocation problem as solved once an assignment is computed, whether over rent [11] or chores [12], implicitly

assuming the assignment is then applied and, where necessary, revisited; roommate-matching research likewise optimises for a stable initial pairing [13] without modelling what happens to that pairing's artefacts once the household composition it assumed no longer holds. Shared housing has drawn empirical attention along other dimensions, including the technology and privacy arrangements co-residents negotiate [14], but not, to our knowledge, whether its written household records track the residents who wrote them. Prior work at this institution has found a comparable pattern in a meeting-room marker caddy's ownership label, where naming a directly responsible individual raised staff confidence in restocking without raising the actual stocked rate or staff recall of who the individual was [15], and in a set of floor-marking arrows that persisted independent of the works order that licensed them, in the absence of any assigned removal authority [16]; by contrast, naming a sole accountable owner for a campus water bubbler did measurably speed its repairs, when the naming carried a maintenance-queue consequence attached to it [17]. The chore-roster whiteboard sits closer to the caddy label than to the bubbler: a name that persists without a mechanism forcing anyone to reconcile it against reality.

Method

Recruitment and eligibility. We recruited share-house chore-roster whiteboards through room-share and lease-transfer noticeboards across the metropolitan area, restricting eligibility to houses whose roster had stood through at least three tenancy turnovers — a departure and a new arrival on the lease — since it was first drawn up, verified against each house's own bond-lodgement or informal lease-transfer records where residents could produce them. This yielded 38 eligible whiteboards.

Concordance measure. For each whiteboard we photographed the roster and recorded every named owner-chore pairing, then cross-referenced each named owner against the house's tenancy record at four points: the roster's original drafting (turnover 0) and after each of the first three subsequent turnovers. A slot was coded concordant at a given turnover if its named owner was a resident of the house at that point. Assignment-residency concordance at turnover t is

$$C_t = \frac{1}{k} \sum_{i=1}^k \mathbb{1}[o_i \text{ resident at } t]$$

where o_i is the named owner of slot i and k is the roster's slot count for that house. We report C_t pooled across the sample and separately by chore category for the four categories common to at least 30 of the 38 rosters (bins, dishes, bathroom, vacuuming).

Interviews. We conducted semi-structured interviews with 58 current residents across the 38 houses (1–2 per house, depending on availability), asking each what they understood the roster to currently mean, how the relevant chores actually got done, and whether the household had discussed redrawing the board. Responses were coded thematically for the reasons given for not redrawing [18].

Redraw ablation. From the interview sample we identified 19 households in which at least one resident explicitly stated, unprompted, an intention to redraw the roster “soon,” and matched each to a household of the same turnover count in which no resident expressed such an intention ($n=19$). We recontacted both groups six months later to record whether a redraw had actually occurred, and compared redraw rates with Fisher's exact test.

Results

Across the 38 whiteboards, assignment-residency concordance fell from 100% at drafting (by construction) to 71% after the first turnover, 46% after the second, and 22% by the third (Figure 1). No house in the sample showed concordance rising between turnovers; the roster only ever drifted further from its household, never back toward it.

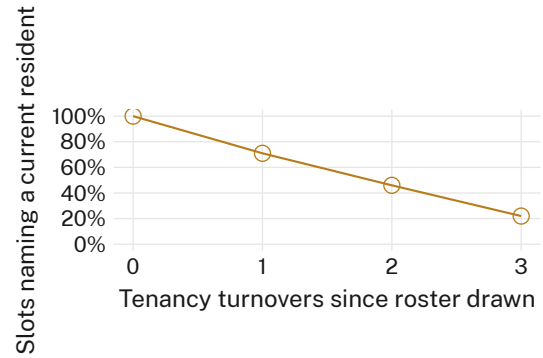


Figure 1: Assignment-residency concordance fell from 100% at drafting to 22% by the third tenancy turnover, across 38 audited whiteboards.

Concordance declined at statistically indistinguishable rates across the four most common chore categories (Figure 2): by the third turnover, bins stood at 25%, dishes at 19%, bathroom at 24%, and vacuuming at 18% (chi-square test of category by turnover-stage interaction, $p=0.89$, n.s.). No category's board entry proved more likely than another's to be updated as its named owner moved out.

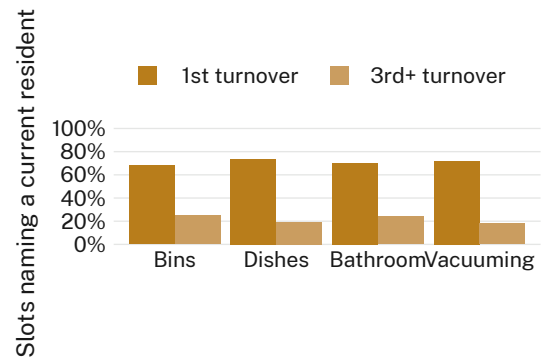


Figure 2: All four common chore categories fell from roughly 70% concordance at the first turnover to under 25% by the third, with no category reliably more durable than the others.

Despite the drift, 51 of the 58 interviewed residents (88%) reported that the relevant chores were, in their assessment, still getting done to a broadly acceptable standard. Asked how, residents described an informal reassignment that never touched the board itself: a departing resident's chore was picked up by whoever was around, by a rotating unspoken understanding, or by the same person who had quietly been doing it for months regardless of the name on the wall. Thematic coding of the 58 interviews found three recurring reasons for not redrawing

the roster: an etiquette concern about erasing a departed or current resident's name without asking them (24 residents, 41%); genuine uncertainty about whose place it was to update a shared object nobody individually owned (19 residents, 33%); and a sense that redrawing was simply unnecessary because the chores were getting done regardless of what the board said (15 residents, 26%).

The redraw ablation found no reliable relationship between a stated intention to redraw and an observed redraw (Figure 3): of the 19 households where a resident had stated an intention to redraw the roster, 2 (11%) had done so within six months; of the 19 matched households where no such intention was stated, 1 (5%) had (Fisher's exact test, $p=0.55$, n.s.). A household's stated plan to update its own record did not measurably improve the odds that it would.

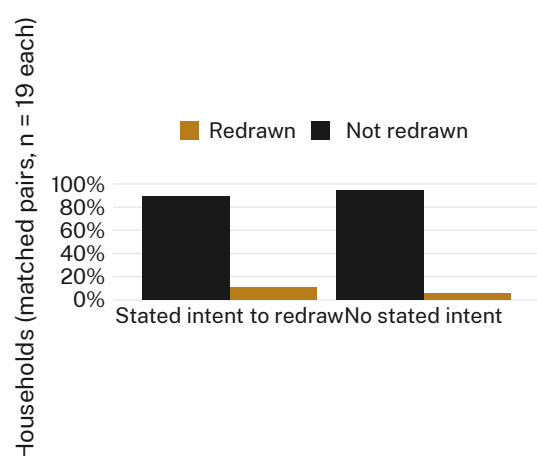


Figure 3: Households with a stated intention to redraw the roster ($n=19$) were no more likely to have actually redrawn it within six months than matched households with no stated intention ($n=19$; 11% versus 5%, Fisher's exact $p=0.55$).

Discussion

The pattern across all three measures points the same way: a chore-roster whiteboard's authority erodes steadily against the household it describes, and the household compensates for that erosion without ever repairing its cause. This sits alongside default-effects research showing an existing arrangement need not clear any bar higher than nobody happening to revise it [3], [4], and alongside descriptive-norm findings that behaviour tracks what people observe each other doing rather than what a posted record instructs [8], [9] — our interviews suggest

a household's actual chore performance has, in effect, migrated onto exactly this descriptive-norm channel, leaving the whiteboard's prescriptive one stranded. The redraw ablation's null result extends the caddy-labelling finding at this institution [15]: stating an intention to fix a stale record does not, on this evidence, predict fixing it, which suggests the barrier to redrawing sits closer to a coordination problem — whose place is it to touch the board — than to a motivational one. We read the etiquette and ownership-uncertainty codes as pointing the same way: a chore roster, unlike a rent split, has no obvious authority to revise it once its founding residents are gone.

Limitations

Our sample is drawn from houses willing to be recruited through room-share and lease-transfer noticeboards, which may under-represent houses whose rosters were abandoned so early that no current resident remembers them as ever having mattered, biasing our concordance estimates upward. Bond-lodgement and lease-transfer records let us date turnovers precisely but not the exact point a slot's concordance lapsed within a turnover window, which coarsens our per-turnover estimates without, we expect, biasing them in either direction. The 19-household matched ablation is likely underpowered to detect a small but real effect of stated intention on redraw behaviour; the finding should be read as showing no large effect, not as ruling out a modest one.

Conclusion

A share-house chore-roster whiteboard, on this evidence, is trusted to keep working long after it has stopped describing anyone in the house it hangs in, because the household finds other ways to get its chores done and no one is assigned the job of noticing the board has fallen behind. The written record and the household's actual practice diverge steadily and, within our sample, permanently, with neither an etiquette barrier nor a stated intention to fix it sufficient to close the gap. Future work might test whether assigning a named review authority to the roster — the same intervention default-effects and organisational-routines research would predict should matter — actually raises concordance, or whether, like a stated intention to redraw, it too turns out to make no measurable difference.

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